



Let's assume you have three levels of callers—'one' for unidentifiable callers, 'two' for friends, and 'three' for VIPs. So when your family sits down to dine, the house will automatically change its status to 'Dinner', and, depending on the setting you've preset, will screen callers from the three levels—for example, only allowing level three calls to come through. It will also give callers from the other two levels a polite reason for not connecting them, and give them a tentative time to call back, or even call them back as soon as you finish dinner—again, all preset.

► Believe It Or Not!

Devices exist that will blow your mind with the advancement of technology they display. Check them out for yourself online.

Solid State Hard Drives: Ahh, a thing of fiction for every hardware junkie. After all, it's the hard drive that's the bottleneck of systems today! But, how about memory-cum-hard drives that offer read speeds of 8 GBps, and write speeds of 6 GBps (a SATA hard drive offers a mere 150 MBps). Quantum Optical memory offers just that, and a 250 GB memory chip-cum-hard drive is about as big as a glucose biscuit! Check out Atom Chip Corporation at www.atomchip.com, and don't miss the Consumer Products link—there's a tablet PC with 250 GB non-volatile memory (RAM + hard drive), and a 4 GHz AtomChip CPU. The products are mainly developed for the US Military, but you can pay the site a visit and dream, can't you?

Not-So-Crazy Ideas: Most of these inventions have to be dreamed up before they are invented. It's a pity not many companies are willing to share their dreams with us. However, the NEC Design studios is kind enough to share some of their future projects online. Visit <http://www.nec-design.co.jp/showcase/> to see some really innovative ideas. We loved their "tag" soft shell mobile phone so much we were inspired to use it in the visual below, as an illustration of the Personal Digital Device (PDD) of the future.

Using secured wireless networks, the house will also connect to various other devices, such as the entertainment centre in the living room to send it instructions about what movies you requested for the evening, or what audio playlist is most popular at this time of day, and on this day of the week.

This house CPU will also monitor the external security camera and watch for movement or people approaching the doors or windows. You will be able to set it to pop up a visual of the person approaching on the video output device in the room you are currently in, while the speakers will play a soft alert sound.

The Kitchen

Keeping with the current popularity of open kitchens, perhaps the kitchen no longer needs to be just that, and can be converted into more of a chore and recreational area.

Devices such as washing machines and dishwashers will connect wirelessly to the house CPU and receive instructions from it. The house CPU will also control other devices such as the refrigerator, your Personal Digital Device (PDD) and the central heating or cooling.

The house CPU informs your family when the fridge is low on food stocks, or when you are running out of dishwasher detergent. It also monitors the functioning of these devices, and will even be able to draw a bath for your family, remembering the temperature that each family member prefers.

On a more personal level, convergence will mean that your house CPU will be the central repository for all your family's personal data. Each

